

Element C.

Design Requirement #1 (HIGH Priority): Safety and Stability

The most important design requirement is making sure the tunnels and enclosure are safe and stable for the rabbits. Rabbits are small, fragile animals, and they can easily get hurt by sharp edges, loose parts, or unstable structures. If the tunnel tips over, collapses, or has metal brackets sticking out, it could seriously harm the rabbits. Our design should use smooth materials, rounded corners, and strong connections so nothing breaks or moves while the rabbits are inside the tunnels. The rabbit's safety must always come first because if they are uncomfortable or scared, they will not want to use the enclosure. A design that harms the rabbits would defeat the entire purpose of building it.

Design Requirement #2 (HIGH Priority): Easy Accessibility

Another high priority is making sure the rabbits are easy to reach at all times. In case of an emergency, such as an injury, illness, or if a rabbit gets stuck, staff members need to be able to quickly and safely reach them. If the enclosure is too complicated or closed off, it could delay help and make the situation worse. Rabbits can panic when trapped, which may cause them to hurt themselves. Having doors, removable sections, or open access points allows keepers to care for the rabbits properly. Easy access also helps with daily tasks like feeding, health checks, and cleaning.

Design Requirement #3 (HIGH Priority): Easy to Take Down and Move

The enclosure and tunnels should be designed so they can be taken apart and moved easily. This is important because the rabbit's living space needs to be cleaned regularly to prevent mold, bacteria, and harmful odors from building up. If the structure is too heavy or complicated, staff may avoid taking it apart, which could lead to unhealthy conditions. Being able to move the enclosure also allows workers to rearrange the space or relocate it if needed. A simple, lightweight, and modular design will make maintenance faster and safer for both the rabbits and the staff.

Design Requirement #4 (HIGH Priority): Easy Reassembly

It is also very important that the enclosure can be put back together easily after being taken apart. If the design is confusing or requires special tools, it may be rebuilt incorrectly, which could make it unsafe. Since there may not always be an instruction manual available, the parts should fit together clearly and only one way. A simple design reduces mistakes and saves time. Easy reassembly ensures that the rabbits are not left without a proper home for long periods and that the structure remains stable and secure.

Design Requirement #5 (HIGH Priority): Enrichment and Play Features

Adding different activities and toys for the rabbits is another high priority. Rabbits are intelligent and curious animals that need mental and physical stimulation to stay healthy. If they become bored, they may develop stress, depression, or destructive behaviors like chewing on unsafe objects. Including tunnels, chew toys, ramps, and hiding spots helps keep them active and engaged. Rotating or changing these features can also prevent boredom. Providing enrichment is part of treating animals humanely and shows respect for their well-being.

Design Requirement #6 (LOW Priority): Special Lighting

Lighting is considered a low priority because the enclosure can usually be lit by the room it is in. Rabbits do not need bright lights and actually prefer softer, natural lighting. Too much light can make them uncomfortable or stressed. While extra lighting may help staff members when cleaning or checking on the rabbits, it does not strongly affect how the rabbits use the enclosure. As long as the space is not too dark or unsafe, special lighting is not necessary.

Design Requirement #7 (LOW Priority): Appearance and Design

The appearance of the enclosure is also a low priority because it does not directly affect the rabbits' health or safety. However, having a neat and attractive design can still be beneficial. A well-designed enclosure looks more professional and fits better into homes, classrooms, or wildlife centers in our case. Choosing colors that don't pop out as much and well organized layouts can make the space more appealing for visitors and caretakers. Even though looks are not as important as function, a clean and appealing design shows that we care and take responsibility.

